

Ukraine's Long War

Military Attrition, the Reconstruction Imperative, and the EU Accession Horizon

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Executive Summary

Ukraine enters its fifth year of full-scale war against Russia in a condition of managed attrition: the front has stabilised following a series of counteroffensives, Western military and financial aid has accumulated to extraordinary scale, and Kyiv continues to leverage the conflict as an accelerant for EU and NATO integration. Yet structural vulnerabilities are deepening. Russia's systematic targeting of energy infrastructure and the Black Sea grain corridor has imposed compounding economic costs, refugee displacement has reached historic levels, and the reconstruction financing architecture remains contested. The central question is no longer whether Ukraine survives, but under what terms and at what cost it consolidates a post-war order.

1. Military Posture and the Negotiation Deadlock

1. Russia's February 2022 invasion was predicated on irredentist ideology, with the Kremlin launching simultaneous offensives from Belarus toward Kyiv, from occupied Crimea in the south, and from Russian-held Donbas in the east. The stated objective — "demilitarisation and denazification" — masked territorial annexation ambitions. [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — encyclopaedic conflict dataset]
2. Ukraine's 2022 counteroffensives reversed significant Russian gains. Ukrainian forces liberated most of Kharkiv Oblast in the east, then in November 2022 retook the city of Kherson and all Ukrainian territory west of the Dnipro River. In August 2024, Ukraine launched a cross-border incursion into Russia's Kursk Oblast, expanding the operational theatre beyond Ukrainian territory for the first time. [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — encyclopaedic conflict dataset]
3. Ceasefire diplomacy remains deadlocked on terms that are structurally incompatible. At talks in Turkey in May 2025, the head of the Russian delegation, Vladimir Medinsky, demanded Ukrainian acceptance of Russian annexation of four regions and warned that future Russian demands could rise to six regions. He stated that "Russia was ready for an endless war against Ukraine." [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — Atlantic Council, February 2026]
4. Ukraine simultaneously applied military pressure on Crimea, symbolic of Russian annexation since 2014. In June 2026, Ukrainian drones struck the Sevastopol power substation, knocking out electricity to the largest city in Russian-held Crimea, signalling that no Russian-held territory is beyond reach. [CNA[2026-07-04]]

2. Western Military Aid: Scale, Composition, and Sustainability

5. The scale of Western military support for Ukraine is historically unprecedented in post-Cold War European security. From January 2022 to January 2024, the Kiel Institute tracked \$380 billion in total aid to Ukraine across all categories. Military assistance has been coordinated through the Ukraine Defence Contact Group, which comprises over fifty countries including all 32 NATO member states. [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — encyclopaedic conflict dataset]
6. US Congressional commitments constitute the largest single bilateral stream. Congress committed over \$40 billion for newly produced equipment, training, and services as security assistance to Ukraine, of which \$20.6 billion had been delivered by end 2025. The United States also delivered \$31.7 billion in weapons and military equipment drawn directly from existing stockpiles. Total Western aid cited across Atlantic Council reporting reached \$267 billion over the first three years of war. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI Military Assistance Report, June 2026]
7. The shift in US arms export geography is structural. For the five-year period 2021–2025, Europe received the largest share of US arms exports — 38 per cent of the total — for the first time in two decades. US arms exports to Europe more than trebled compared with the prior five-year period 2016–2020, a 217 per cent increase. A quarter of all US arms exports to Europe in 2021–2025 went to Ukraine, equivalent to 9.4 per cent of total global US arms exports. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI Trends in International Arms Transfers 2025]
8. Eastern European defence spending has surged in response to the war. Military expenditure across Eastern Europe rose 24 per cent in 2024, reaching \$221 billion — the highest level since the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Eastern European military spending grew 164 per cent over the decade 2015–2024. Ukraine's own military expenditure grew 2.9 per cent in 2024. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI Trends in World Military Expenditure 2024]
9. Equipment attrition is a persistent operational constraint. Ukrainian artillery tubes require frequent repair due to the intensity of usage, reflecting the attritional character of the eastern front. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — Congressional Research Service, Defense Production for Ukraine, September 2024]

3. Energy Infrastructure War and the Black Sea Grain Corridor

10. Russia's systematic targeting of Ukrainian energy infrastructure constitutes a deliberate strategy of economic coercion applied to the civilian population. In July 2025, Russia attacked cities across Ukraine with hundreds of drones in a single overnight operation, striking energy infrastructure in multiple regions. [CNA[2025-07-16]]
11. In a September 2025 attack, Russian drones struck power facilities in northern and southern Ukraine overnight, leaving nearly 60,000 customers without electricity. A simultaneous strike on Chernihiv region damaged energy infrastructure and left 30,000 households without power, including parts of the city of Nizhyn. Ukraine's military confirmed Russia had deployed 142 drones in that operation, with air defences shooting down most but 10 locations sustaining strikes. [CNA[2025-09-01]]
12. Russian strikes continued against residential areas. In November 2025, Russia struck apartment blocks in Kyiv, killing six people in a single attack that President Zelenskyy condemned publicly. [CNA[2025-11-14]]
13. A limited ceasefire framework covering energy infrastructure was explored by March 2025, following US President Donald Trump's calls with both Ukrainian and Russian leadership. Analysts assessed such a targeted ceasefire as a necessary but insufficient first step toward a broader settlement. [CNA[2025-03-20]]
14. The Black Sea grain corridor has become a second vector of economic warfare. Russia's de facto blockade of Ukrainian Black Sea ports in the Odesa region sent Ukrainian grain exports tumbling 76 per

cent year-on-year in August 2026, with the agricultural sector warning of severe economic consequences should the blockade persist. [CNA[2026-08-13]]

15. Ukraine proposed, through a third party, a mutual halt to attacks on civilian targets in the Black Sea as escalating strikes threatened grain exports and global food supplies. Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan confirmed that a moratorium proposal had been conveyed to both parties. Russia stated it had received no formal proposal. [CNA[2026-08-13]]

16. A satellite image confirmed damage to a grain conveyor following a Ukrainian drone and missile strike on Novorossiysk, Russia, on 12 August 2026 — illustrating the reciprocal character of the maritime targeting campaign. [CNA[2026-08-13]]

17. The destruction of grain export capacity has historical precedent in the current war. In spring 2022, Ukrainian grain exports had already collapsed from approximately six million tonnes per month to under one million tonnes as Russia blocked Black Sea ports. Global wheat prices soared by more than 50 per cent. The United Nations subsequently assisted in building six million tonnes of storage capacity to allow farmers to store grain while export routes were negotiated. [CNA[2023-03-10]]

4. Reconstruction Financing and the EU-NATO Integration Pathway

18. Ukraine's economy, while considerably smaller than its pre-war size, has shown signs of adaptation and incremental recovery. By late 2023, business activity and consumption were picking up, with observers noting that Ukraine appeared to be adjusting to wartime conditions. [CNA[2023-12-18]]

19. The reconstruction financing architecture centres on the question of mobilising the approximately \$300 billion in Russian sovereign assets frozen in Western jurisdictions following the February 2022 invasion. The Atlantic Council's Transatlantic Horizons 2024 report documented active advocacy — by Philip Zelikow, Robert Zoellick, and Lawrence Summers among others — for redirecting the proceeds of these assets directly to Ukraine. [RAG: THINK_TANK_RAG — Atlantic Council Transatlantic Horizons 2024]

20. EU involvement in postwar reconstruction activities is assessed as a mechanism that could simultaneously accelerate Ukraine's EU accession timeline by facilitating adoption of EU regulatory standards and norms. RAND analysis found that the joint EU-Ukraine reconstruction framework could be structured to advance both economic recovery and institutional alignment objectives in parallel. [RAG: THINK_TANK_RAG — RAND, Will Europe Hold? 2024]

21. The political debate on NATO membership for Ukraine has shifted materially since 2022. The prospect of Ukrainian NATO membership, once widely considered too provocative to Russia to be feasible, attracted revised support from figures including Henry Kissinger, who changed his position to support membership following Russia's battlefield performance and conduct of the war. Russian military weakness, coupled with the targeting of civilian infrastructure, restructured the Western calculus on whether keeping Ukraine outside NATO still served as a credible deterrence mechanism. [CNA[2023-07-14]]

22. Ukraine's displacement crisis is among the largest globally. As of the IOM World Migration Report 2024 baseline, close to 2.6 million Ukrainians were hosted in neighbouring countries — principally Poland, Moldova, and Czechia — with a further approximately 3 million in other European countries and further afield. By end of 2022, Ukraine ranked among the top 10 source countries for refugees globally under UNHCR's mandate. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024]

Outlook

The Ukrainian theatre in mid-2026 presents a conflict in which neither side has achieved decisive military resolution, but in which the structural asymmetries are becoming clearer. Russia sustains territorial pressure along the eastern front but has failed to achieve its strategic objective of subjugating Ukraine. Ukraine has demonstrated the capacity to strike deep into Russian-held territory — including Crimea and Kursk Oblast — and to impose costs on Russian export infrastructure through the Black Sea campaign.

Western military and financial support has been institutionalised at a scale that transforms Ukraine's defence capacity but introduces sustainability questions as the conflict extends. The critical near-term variables are: (1) whether the Black Sea moratorium proposal advances to a formal ceasefire, stabilising grain export revenues; (2) the timeline and legal architecture for mobilising frozen Russian sovereign assets for reconstruction; and (3) whether EU accession negotiations, now explicitly linked to reconstruction programming, generate sufficient institutional momentum to anchor Ukraine's post-war trajectory within the European order.

The negotiation dynamics as of mid-2026 remain locked. Russia's stated demand for four regions, combined with its publicly declared readiness for indefinite war, signals that no settlement is proximate on terms acceptable to Kyiv. Ukraine's integration pathway — into both the EU and NATO — accordingly operates on a parallel track: not contingent on a peace agreement, but advanced incrementally through the very mechanisms of wartime support that have reshaped Alliance posture since 2022.

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